Revision assignments

The mystery of whether the megafauna vanished gradually or in one great wave remains. Were they overhunted, did changes in burning practices harm them or was climate to blame? Many believe that climate was largely responsible while others disagree. Most likely a combination of factors was responsible, with some more harmful than others. Dwarfing is an interesting, but closed, option since we are as yet unable to verify it occurred (and, if so, to which species). Perhaps many of the megafauna species that we consider to be extinct are alive and well, simply concealed in dwarfed bodies.

1 Write a report on, or debate, the theories presented for megafaunal extinction. Consider the pros and cons of each theory. Supporting your argument using information based on the theories, conclude with your own opinion. Put your ideas down in note form. Include a bibliography.

Mental challenge!

Research was undertaken at a number of sites where macropods (kangaroos) were often killed on busy motorways. The results indicated that in most instances, the road kills were male. Figures ranged from 65-92%, depending on location. The species varied, indicating that it is not a particular type of kangaroo that tends to be killed.

2 Suggest at least three possible explanations why males represented the largest proportion of kangaroos that are hit by vehicles.

3 What does your answer to Question 2 indicate about possible differences between male and female macropods?

4 There is a connection between leaving dead animals (from vehicle kills) on the road and the deaths of more, often different species. For example, leaving a dead kangaroo on a road often results in birds and lizards being killed. Why?

5 The cassowary, emu, ostrich, kiwi and rhea are all distantly related animals only found in the southern hemisphere. Name two things that they have in common.

6 Kangaroos raise many emotions among Australians. Consider the following people who might be involved with kangaroos and outline why they may be either 'for' or 'against' kangaroos.

a graziers

b conservationists

c motorists

d Aboriginal peoples



7 Outline the advantages of burning large areas of Australian bush.

8 Why might some people be concerned about current burning of bushland?

Research

9 Find out the role played by the volunteer organisation WIRES.

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